

Democrats hit Epstein drumbeat in shutdown

Party using holdup over release of files as another pressure point on GOP

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When Senators Ruben Gallego and Mark Kelly, both Democrats from Arizona, held an impromptu press conference outside Speaker Mike Johnson’s office Wednesday, they sought to needle Republicans with their health care-focused messaging amid the ongoing government shutdown.

But when Johnson unexpectedly came out to engage them, the moment offered an opportunity to highlight the other political pressure point Democrats are most eager to exploit: Republicans’ handling of sensitive files about the late convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

In front of the cameras, Gallego quickly confronted Johnson, alleging he kept the House in recess last week — and delayed the swearing-in of a newly elected Democratic representative from Arizona — in order to slow-walk a bipartisan effort to get the so-called Epstein files released.

“It has nothing to do with Epstein,” insisted Johnson, who argued the review of the files by a House committee will take time in order to respect victims’ identities.

EPSTEIN, Page A18

Boston’s lead in biotech faces global rivals

China, UK surging while industry here is struggling

By Shirley Leung
GLOBE COLUMNIST

For more than a decade, Boston has been the undisputed capital of the world’s life sciences industry. No other city really comes close.

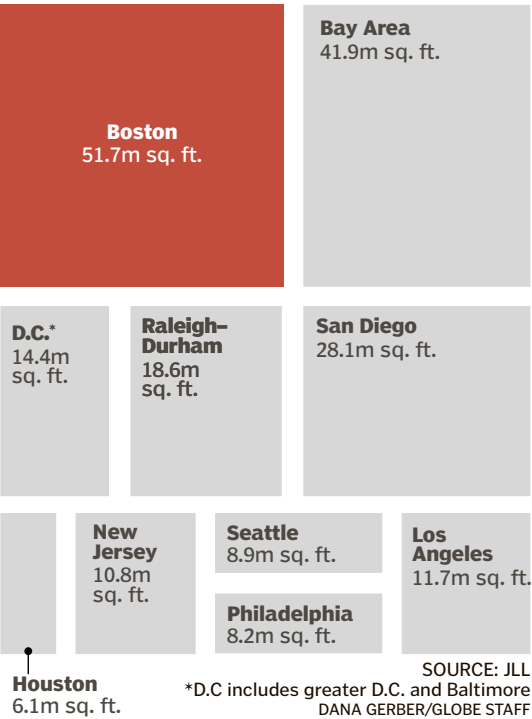
There is more lab space in Boston and Cambridge than anywhere in the world. Billions of dollars in venture capital flow into the region fueling startups, while billions more come from the federal government to fund research. It’s an enviable economic engine that has nearly doubled biopharma employment over the past decade and powered our region’s prosperity.

But what about now? With the Trump administration threatening key ingredients of Boston’s recipe for biotech success — including federal grants and visas for international students and workers — could some other place rise to become the next Boston?

Probably not, is the simple answer. It would be hard for any place to replicate the tight-knit sci-

BIOTECH, Page A19

Lab market inventory for the top 10 US life sciences hubs of 2025



Tens of thousands of Palestinians returned to their neighborhoods, and Israelis cheered Monday’s expected release of remaining hostages. **A2.**

Globe Santa is back, marking 70 years of delivering gifts and hope. **B1.**

The Globe Magazine isn’t publishing today. Puzzles are on B4.



Glum line

Sunday: Cloudy, windy. High: 57-62. Low: 52-57.

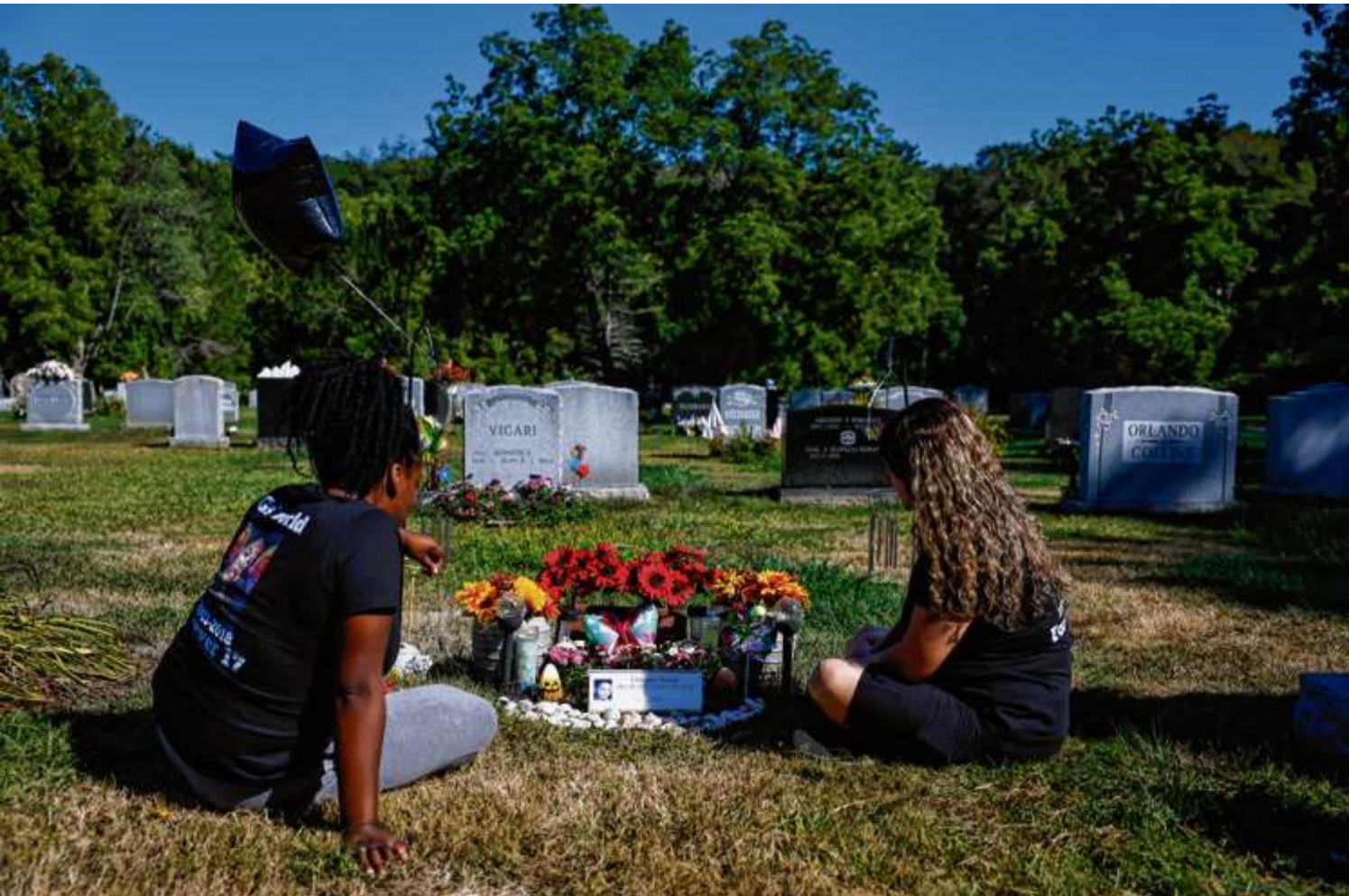
Monday: Rain, wind. High: 55-60. Low: 51-56.

Complete report, **A26.**

The lost children

Hundreds of kids in the state’s care go missing every year, many to end up in the sex trade. Lax oversight, other mistakes contribute to the crisis.

STORY BY TRICIA L. NADOLNY, JASON LAUGHLIN, AND SCOOTY NICKERSON | GLOBE STAFF



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

There was only one bed available at Pathways, a Bradford group home for teens in crisis, when a state worker secured a spot there for G Araujo.

The home was supposed to be a haven for the vulnerable 17-year-old from Gloucester.

Araujo had begun gingerly embracing a gender transition, experimenting with makeup and women’s clothing, while leaning away from her birth name, Gustavo. At the same time, her home life was strained, and she struggled with drugs. Placed in a foster home, she kept missing curfew. The foster parents worried she needed more supervision than they could provide.

Araujo was uneasy as she arrived at Pathways and grew more so in the coming hours. The next day, she told staff she felt lonely. Repeatedly, she said she wanted to run and use drugs.

Yet her duress did not set off alarms. No one notified the home’s on-call administrator, who could have ordered crisis intervention for the teen.

That night, Araujo ran.

Two days after that, she was found dead of an accidental overdose following a house party, surrounded by drug paraphernalia and an empty bottle of alcohol.

“I read it as a cry for help,” Alexia Thompson, a friend of Araujo’s since middle school, said after reading the state’s report on her final days. “And they really weren’t seeing that.”

Araujo’s 2018 death, never before reported, represents the most alarming outcome of a near-daily occurrence for children in Massachusetts’s care. They run away. They go missing. And the consequences can be dire.

Some return quickly, while others



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Top: Tyla Ordoñez (left) and Skye Foote at the grave of their friend G Araujo in Gloucester. **Above:** Alexia Thompson held a yearbook open to a page memorializing Araujo.

spend weeks or months on the run. Others are never found. While gone, many are lured into the world’s darkest corners, becoming victims of sex trafficking.

In a typical year, roughly 600 children in the care of the Massachusetts Department of Children and Families are counted as missing.

That’s roughly 1 in 22 of all children in the state’s custody, according to a Globe analysis of state and federal data. But running is far more frequent for older children in the system. Among teens, more than 1 in 7 go missing at least once.

LOST, Page A16

Trump’s anti-DEI push a unique challenge for women’s colleges

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

NORTHAMPTON — Margot Audero, a senior at Smith College, remembers the first time she ever saw a transgender person: Caitlyn Jenner on the cover of Vanity Fair in 2015. “I thought it was gross,” she said, “because that was what society had taught me to believe.”

An adolescent boy at the time who had long wanted to be a girl, Audero hadn’t realized changing her gender was even possible until that moment. Her dawning awareness came at a critical moment when women’s colleges were going through their own identity transitions.

The same year Jenner brought trans visibility to the main-

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JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Smith College senior Margot Audero is known for wearing a large trans pride flag as a cape.

